

you'll need to change the way you use the keyboard and mouse—working with Blender is a dream when you use both together. You don't even need an exceptional machine to run it—it works smoothly even on mid-range PCs, stuttering a bit only when you load too many objects into your scene (as expected, of course).

Apart from letting budding 3D artists explore their skills, Blender comes well-loaded for professionals as well. It has a competent database system built into it, which lets you share objects across different projects, skeletal animation for creating realistic characters, and Python scripting to create your own custom effects and animations.

Finally, you can even create your own games in Blender, though not without some programming knowledge.

Site: www.blender.org

4.3.2 Wings 3D

Wings 3D is a tool for creating 3D models, and doesn't pretend to be anything else. The very simple interface lets you get straight down to your box-modelling business without any real learning curve. All you need to know is that the mouse's middle-click puts you in the "orbit" mode, left-clicking selects objects or their elements and the right-click brings up the context-sensitive menu, and you're set. Wings is built on the Erlang programming language, and lets you key in Erlang code while the program is running.

If you're looking to build models with high levels of detail and tremendous complexity, though, Wings shouldn't be your first choice. While it excels with low-polygon models (best used if you're making or modding a game), Wings does tend to get sluggish with more intricate models.

Wings has only a basic renderer, so you'll need to pair it with something more powerful like POV-Ray (read about it later in this chapter). It also has no support for animation, so once you've built